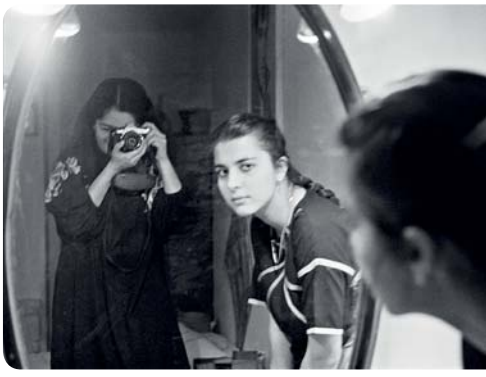


Like any 'big novel', Let's See covers the gamut of human experience with all its highs and lows, but with a perceptible lightness







LET'S SEE
By Dayanita Singh
STEIDL
₹2,633;
304 pages

It was Ernst Battenberg, a German publisher, who gifted Dayanita Singh her first camera. Singh used the Pentax ME Super judiciously. In the 1980s, she had little choice: "At NID [Ahmedabad's National Institute of Design], I would make my own contact sheets. Nobody could afford giving them to labs. Also, making prints was an unimaginable luxury." Instead of the usual 36, she would try to eke out 38 frames from a roll of film. Singh was not greedy or parsimonious. The times were frugal.

Homebound during the pandemic, Singh pored over her contact sheets, "the heart of her work". When looking at her photographs from 1981 to 1993 laid out in front of her, she instinctively knew she had a photo-novel on her hands. "But I didn't want the book to have a beautiful image on one page and another beautiful image alongside it," she says, "I wanted the photos to do what text does."

For Milan Kundera, "the novel's spirit is the spirit of continuity—a thing made to last, to connect the past with the future". Of the many novelistic things that Singh's *Let's See* does, it first meets this Kundera precondition. When, for instance, we see Singh's subjects flipping photo albums, we think of the photographer herself, bent over her contact sheets—but we also see our reading selves mirrored. Rather than dramatic acts, this book is made of these small gestures. And almost all are generous.

Singh's pictures are often marked by an abundance of affection. At her NID hostel where she stayed, or at the weddings and wakes she attends, people leaned on one another for comfort. They physically demonstrated the intimacy they felt. "Today, if I just put my hand on your hand, you'd freeze, but resting your arm on someone's shoulder while talking to them was the most normal thing to do—that's how we all were in the '80s and '90s," says Singh.

Reading *Let's See*, it is hard not to yearn for an age where conversations were effortless and smokers weren't pariahs, but Singh clarifies that she never meant the book to be an ode to simpler times. "I'm not a sentimental person, so it was very important that this cannot be sentimental nostalgia." As with any 'big novel,' *Let's See* also covers the gamut of human life—everything from childhood to death, from fun to mourning—but it does so with a perceptible lightness.

Seeing how their work is bound by the limits of reality, it is often hard for photographers to have a conspicuous sense of humour. Singh, however, does force you to chuckle with her cheeky editing. Though the rifles we see in her portrait of K.P.S. Gill are all real and menacing, she quickly follows this up with the picture of a man showing off